

Appendix A

Synthesis of the Guiding Characteristics of Literature Review Writing

The four perspectives discussed in the preceding sections examine literature review writing from complementary viewpoints. The rhetorical organisation perspective explains how literature reviews are organised through rhetorical moves, the argumentative process perspective explains how literature reviews progressively construct the justification for research, and the content expectations perspective identifies the information and presentation expected by expert readers. Together, these three perspectives converge on a common set of guiding characteristics that define the structure, purpose, and content of effective literature reviews. The literature on styles of literature reviews and transformation of source information complements these characteristics by explaining how evidence from source papers should be synthesised and transformed into an integrated academic narrative. Collectively, these perspectives provide the conceptual basis from which the guiding characteristics of literature review writing adopted in this thesis are derived.

The first three perspectives share several common principles despite being developed from different theoretical and methodological traditions. As shown in Table 2.1, they consistently reject the view of the literature review as a descriptive summary and instead emphasise its role in establishing the research context, reviewing previous studies, identifying research gaps, justifying the current study, and explaining the contribution. These common characteristics represent the core functions of literature review writing that are consistently recognised across the literature.

Table A.1: Similarities among the Three Perspectives

Common Feature	Rhetorical Organisation	Argumentative Process	Content Expectations
Literature review is more than a summary	✓	✓	✓
Establishes research context	✓	✓	✓
Reviews previous research	✓	✓	✓
Identifies research gaps	✓	✓	✓
Justifies the current study	✓	✓	✓
Explains the research contribution	✓	✓	✓

While the first three perspectives establish the common conceptual characteristics of literature review writing, the literature on styles of literature reviews and transformation of source information contributes additional characteristics that complement, rather than duplicate, these principles. Jaidka et al. (2013) distinguish between descriptive and integrative literature reviews and show that these styles differ primarily in the extent to which evidence from multiple studies is synthesised and source information is transformed. This perspective therefore contributes two complementary guiding characteristics to the conceptual foundations of literature review writing: (1) synthesising evidence across multiple studies and (2) transforming source information through paraphrasing, summarisation, and critical references.

Taken together, the common guiding characteristics summarised in Table 2.1 and the complementary guiding characteristics identified from the literature on styles of literature

reviews and transformation of source information indicate that effective literature review writing is characterised by coherent rhetorical organisation, progressive construction of the research argument, inclusion of the information expected by expert readers, synthesis of evidence across multiple studies, and transformation of source information into an integrated academic narrative. The synthesis presented in this appendix provides the conceptual basis from which the seven guiding characteristics of literature review writing presented in Section 2.1.6 are derived.